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‘PARTY OF RAM’

A Hindu Suratrana, the Idea of ‘New India’ and Its Global Message

It is the death of the Republic, lamented one of the few liberals on my school alumni WhatsApp group. As the image of Prime Minister Narendra Modi presiding over the bhoomi-pujan of the new Ram Temple in Ayodhya streamed on television screens and other devices across India on 5 August 2020, the WhatsApp group erupted. The morning started with ‘Ram-Ram’ messages and people posting celebratory Ram imagery on the group. Then one of the Modi-bhakts on the group posted a ‘Nation with Namo’ political pamphlet, listing ‘decades-long pending issues’ the Modi government had ‘resolved’ in ‘just six years’. Prominently listed was the Ram Temple dispute. To this, my liberal friend answered, ‘You must add on the list highest unemployment in 45 years, highest territory ceded to China in 60 years, highest diesel prices’. It was the kind of argument that had become almost a daily ritual on this group between the same set of Left- and Right-leaning individuals. But that day, as the puja began in Ayodhya, some of the political neutrals jumped in. ‘Bhai, let it be today,’ one counselled the liberal. ‘Today is a historic day. Please keep agendas aside.’ On screen, Modi had just been anointed with a saffron turban and a silver mukut (crown) by the priests of the Hanumangarhi temple. He was now doing a dandvat pranam,[1] lying prostrate on the floor with his hands folded